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WAM

■ His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, boards an Etihad Rail passenger train from Dubai to Fujairah on a test ride on Saturday to review the progress of the country's first national rail network, scheduled to commence operations in 2026.

Etihad Rail chairman thanks Mohammad for train journey

Theyab expresses gratitude to Dubai Ruler over support to Etihad Rail

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

Shaikh Theyab Bin Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Chairman of Etihad Rail, has sent a letter of thanks and appreciation to His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, following His Highness's journey on an Etihad Rail passenger train on Saturday.

The full text of the letter reads as follows:

"We have been honoured to host my father, His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, on board an Etihad Rail passenger train journey between the emirates of Dubai and Fujairah. This step reflects the commitment of the



■ Shaikh Theyab Bin Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan

UAE's wise leadership to support national projects that contribute to the advancement of our nation.

"This is what we have come to expect from His Highness Shaikh Mohammad, as he has witnessed the development of the network at various stages: from the announcement of the '50 Projects' in 2021, through his inauguration of the complete national railway network and the launch of cargo train

operations in 2023, to today, when we are on the verge of a transformative phase in the country's transport sector.

"We take pride in, and deeply value, the support we have received for our national project, which leads us towards a better future, enhancing connectivity and economic integration across the country, serving the interests of our nation and elevating its global competitiveness."

Earlier, Shaikh Mohammad wrote on his official X account: "We have made the journey from Dubai to Fujairah on the Etihad Rail passenger train ... The train will connect 11 cities and regions across the UAE, from Al Sila to Fujairah, with a speed of 200km/h. It is expected to carry 36 million passengers annually by 2030.

"I'm proud of our national projects. I'm proud of the Etihad Rail team led by Shaikh Theyab Bin Mohammad Bin Zayed. And I'm proud of a nation that never stops working — one that adds a new brick to its future infrastructure every single day."

SEE ALSO P2

Opec+ agrees output hike to finish unwinding cuts

Opec+ completes its current tranche of supply revival one year early

DUBAI

Opec+ agreed on another bumper oil production increase for September, completing its current tranche of supply revival one year early as the group moves to reclaim its share of global crude markets.

Saudi Arabia and its partners agreed on a video conference to add about 548,000 barrels a day next month, delegates said. This completes the reversal of a 2.2 million-barrel cutback made by eight members in 2023, and also includes an extra allowance being phased by the UAE.

Another layer of about

1.66-million barrels of halted output will be reviewed by the end of December, one of the delegates said.

Dramatic shift

The latest hike caps a dramatic shift from the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its partners from defending prices to opening the taps, which has helped put a lid on oil and gasoline futures in the face of geopolitical tensions and strong seasonal demand, offering some relief for drivers and a win for US President Donald Trump. The accelerated increases have helped fuel expectations for a global supply surplus later in the year.

Yesterday's decision, confirming an agreement in principle, also comes as President Trump intensifies diplomatic pressure on Opec+ co-leader Russia.

— Bloomberg

Dubai sees over 9.88m visitors in first half

A 6% RISE FROM H1 2024 SHOWS STEADY TOURISM GROWTH

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

Dubai's evolving destination offering, driven by impactful public-private partnerships and amplified through a robust global marketing strategy, resulted in the city welcoming 9.88 million international overnight visitors from January to June 2025 — a 6 per cent increase compared to the same period in 2024, according to data published by the Dubai Department of Economy and Tourism (DET).

Shaikh Hamdan Bin Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister, Minister of Defence, and Chairman of Dubai Executive Council, said, "Dubai continues to set new records in international visitation, reinforcing the strategic vision of His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, to make the city a major global business and tourism destination.

World's most connected city

"This milestone reflects Dubai's steady growth as a focal point for trade, investment, talent and opportunity and its rise as the world's most connected city. Dubai's ability to create compelling experiences that meet the evolving needs of visitors has strengthened its status as one of the world's most sought-after destinations. From exceptional infrastructure to unique attractions, Dubai offers a model of excellence in the tourism and hospitality sectors grounded in

22%

visitors were from Western Europe, at 2.12 million

26%

combined visitors from GCC and Mena proximity markets

innovation. As we advance the goals of the Dubai Economic Agenda D33, tourism will remain key to driving GDP growth and cross-sector value creation in the emirate's economy. By continually anticipating the needs of travellers and exceeding their expectations, we are strengthening Dubai's position as the world's best city to visit, live, and work in."

Partnerships, global campaigns, events, and a series of new openings showcased the city to both new and returning international visitors, while DET's bespoke market strategy, working in collaboration with more than 3,000 global and domestic partners, led to growth in key regions.

According to the DET data, the GCC and Mena proximity markets had a combined 26 per cent share of overall visitors to Dubai from January to June 2025, with 1.51 million (15 per cent) and 1.12 million (11 per cent) arrivals, respectively.

Western Europe was the largest source market to Dubai, with 2.12

million visitors (22 per cent), followed by CIS and Eastern Europe (15 per cent), South Asia (15 per cent), North East and South East Asia (9 per cent), the Americas (7 per cent), Africa (4 per cent) and Australasia (2 per cent).

Preferred travel destination

With unique offerings, safety and connectivity, Dubai has sustained its status as a preferred travel destination for visitors from both traditional and emerging markets. Adding to its appeal for international audiences, Dubai's accommodation portfolio continues to evolve, offering quality at every price point. In the first six months of 2025, the city expanded its hotel inventory with new openings across all segments and in various locations, including Jumeirah Marsa Al Arab in Umm Suqeim, Cheval Maison in Expo City, The Biltmore Hotel Villas in Al Barsha, and Vida Dubai Mall in Downtown Dubai.

From January to June 2025, average occupancy for hotels in Dubai stood at 80.6 per cent, up from 78.7 per cent compared to the same period in 2024.

Occupied room nights increased by 4 per cent, with 22.24 million at the end of H1 2025, compared to 21.35 million in H1 2024, with guests' length of stay averaging 3.71 nights. The average daily rate (ADR) rose to Dh584 during H1, an increase of 5 per cent compared to 2024, while revenue per available room (RevPAR) increased by 7 per cent compared to last year, from Dh439 to Dh471. Meanwhile, the total available rooms in Dubai reached 152,483 by the end of June 2025, with the number of establishments standing at 822.

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